CHAPTER 8 · ASSERT THE STANDARD

Hard vs. Serious

Both demand high performance. Only one actually builds it — because only one models it first.

The Hard Leader	The Serious Leader
Enforces through fear *People perform only when watched*	Inspires through standards *People perform because they believe*
Culture collapses when the leader leaves *Built on one person, not on values*	Culture outlasts the leader *The standard lives in the organisation's DNA*
Creates suppression *Good ideas are never spoken*	Creates ownership *Every person leads at their level*
Mistakes are punished *No learning. Only hiding.*	Mistakes become learning *Psychological safety enables honesty*
Team full of yes-people *Capable leaders become silent followers*	Team full of leaders *Talent multiplied, not suppressed*
Drives BUSYness *Activity replaces performance*	Drives High Performance *Meaning that compounds over time*

> *"The organisation does not do what the CEO says. It does what the CEO does — consistently, reliably, with a precision that no policy document can match."*

Kill BUSYness, Get High Performance · Manoj Onkar

CHAPTER 8

Assert the Standard

> *"The organisation does not do what the CEO says. It does what the CEO does."*

Demand what you are willing to model. Model what you are willing to live.

Before we talk about what a CEO must demand of others, there is a prerequisite. Non-negotiable. It comes before everything else in this chapter.

The CEO must be willing to personally live every standard they intend to demand.

This is not a principle of good management. It is a law of organisational physics.

Edgar Schein's research at Harvard Business School — the work that defined the field of organisational culture — established that culture is shaped by what leaders pay attention to, measure, and react to. Not what they say. Not what they write in values statements. Not what they present in culture workshops. What they *do* — consistently, in the room, under pressure, when it would be easier to let something slide. Schein's conclusion was precise: "Culture is ultimately created, embedded, evolved, and manipulated by leaders. And when leaders cannot change culture, they must change leaders."

When the CEO needs a follow-up message for something they agreed would be No Follow-Up Required, the organisation receives a message. When the CEO shortcuts a process because the quarter is urgent, the organisation receives a message. When the CEO builds a silo through territorial behaviour while speaking about collaboration, the organisation receives a message.

And these messages — delivered not through words but through action — are the ones that actually shape culture.

So before any non-negotiable is named, the leader must ask honestly: Am I willing to live this first?

Hard vs. Serious

There is a distinction that matters enormously here — because confusing the two produces very different organisations.

Hard leaders demand compliance. They enforce through fear. People perform when watched. The culture ends — or reverts — when they leave.

Serious leaders demand excellence. They inspire through the standards they hold first. People perform because they believe. The culture outlasts their tenure.

We have seen both versions play out directly in the organisations we work with.

A group chairperson — highly intelligent, deeply knowledgeable, and ambitious for his companies — had been driving his entire group in the directions he saw fit. Most of his decisions were sound. But the method was not working. The leaders around him were executing rather than leading. After participating in our programmes, something shifted — in him first, and then in the culture around him. He and his leadership team moved toward collective leadership and co-creation. Each company CEO became genuinely empowered. They in turn began empowering their own leadership teams. The standard did not weaken. It deepened — because it was now owned rather than enforced. This is the transformation from hard to serious.

The contrast was made clear by a second engagement — and this one is the more instructive of the two, because it shows precisely

what happens when a leader engages with the ideas but refuses the personal transformation.

A group CEO, headquartered in Delhi, attended our programmes. He was intelligent, widely read, and genuinely ambitious for his companies. He absorbed the frameworks fluently. He could use the language of collective leadership, of empowerment, of NFR culture, with ease. He sent his leadership teams through our programmes with genuine conviction that they needed to change.

He did not change.

The distinction between the group chairperson's transformation and this CEO's response was not one of intelligence or ambition — both had these in equal measure. The distinction was this: the chairperson was willing to examine his own behaviour as the source of the problem. The Delhi CEO consistently located the source of the problem in others. His teams needed to learn. His managers needed to develop. The culture needed to shift. He was the one holding the vision while everyone else caught up.

The result, as of today, is an organisation full of capable, committed leaders who are suppressed. They have ideas — real ones. They can see problems the CEO cannot see from the top. They have solutions they are afraid to propose, because experience has taught them that initiative is not rewarded here — it is absorbed, overridden, or quietly redirected. They are not disengaged. They are frustrated. Not because they do not care, but because they care deeply and have nowhere to put it.

This is the hidden cost of the leader who changes the language but not the behaviour. The organisation does not get clarity — it gets confusion. People cannot tell whether the stated values are real or performed. And in that ambiguity, the safest strategy is always to wait and watch, rather than to lead.

Two leaders. Similar intelligence. Similar ambition. Fundamentally different outcomes. The difference was not capability. It was the willingness to change first — personally, visibly, without waiting for others to go first.

Google's Project Aristotle — the most rigorous study of team performance ever conducted — reached a finding that directly validates this distinction. The highest-performing teams had both psychological safety *and* high standards. Not safety instead of standards. Not standards instead of safety. Both, simultaneously. Safety did not lower the bar. It enabled people to maintain higher standards because they could admit failure, learn quickly, and course-correct without the fear that honest reporting would be punished.

This is the serious leader's operating reality. Compliance performs when watched. Commitment performs because it has internalised what the standard is for.

The Four Non-Negotiables

These are not suggestions. They are not aspirations. They are the CEO's personal covenant with the organisation — lived first,

demanded second. Each one is a standard that, when held firmly, changes the architecture of how the organisation functions.

Non-Negotiable One: No Follow-Up Required.

The NFR standard requires four things: clear commitments, clear execution, proactive communication the moment risk emerges, and a CEO who holds the standard without exception. Not sometimes. Every time. For every person. At every level. Beginning with themselves.

How many follow-ups did you send last week that should not have been necessary? Multiply that number by fifty-two. That is the annual volume of cultural noise your organisation is generating — telling people that commitments are optional.

The standard ends there. With that count. And with the decision to make it zero.

Non-Negotiable Two: World-Class Best Practices in Every Function.

Every function must operate at the standard of global best practice. Not the local market standard. Not the industry average. Not "good for our size." What the best organisations in the world have demonstrated is possible.

Amazon's Leadership Principle #7 — "Insist on the Highest Standards" — describes leaders as having "relentlessly high standards — many people may think these standards are unreasonably high." Applied in every hiring decision, product review, and customer interaction. Not as aspiration. As a filter.

When the answer to "Does this meet the bar?" is no, the bar does not lower to accommodate the output. The output is returned and rebuilt.

South Korea's POSCO offers one of the most dramatic proofs of what asserting world-class standards from the very beginning actually produces. When POSCO was established in 1968, South Korea had no steel industry, no relevant expertise, and no obvious reason to believe it could build one. The founding leadership did not set adequate standards. They set world-class ones — from Day 1, before any capability existed to meet them. The assertion preceded the capability. The capability grew to meet the standard. Within twenty years, POSCO had become one of the world's most efficient steel producers. Within thirty years, it was globally ranked Number 1 in steel quality and productivity. Standards asserted deliberately and held firmly — not as aspiration, but as the non-negotiable floor — produced a world-leading organisation from conditions that offered no obvious reason to expect one. This is the exact mechanism this chapter describes. Assert the standard first. Then build the capability to live it.

The organisation that defers development investment is not managing costs. It is accumulating a competency deficit that will one day present its bill.

Non-Negotiable Three: Break the Silo.

Departmentalism is a cancer for the organisation. This language is deliberate. A cancer is not a difficulty to be managed. It is a condition that, if not addressed directly, spreads.

Four truths every leader in the organisation must hear, internalise, and live by:

1. If you are married to the department, you are divorced from the company.
2. If you are loyal to the department, you are a problem for the company.
3. Departments are not real — they are just a work distribution mechanism.
4. There are no successful departments in a failed company.

The CEO must demand — not encourage, not suggest, not facilitate — active, visible, structurally supported collaboration across every function. Refusing to allow territorial behaviour regardless of the seniority of the person exhibiting it.

In 1980, Ford called on W. Edwards Deming as Japanese competition drove their market share toward a crisis point. Deming's diagnosis was not a product problem or a technology problem. It was a silo problem. Ford's departments were optimising their own metrics at the expense of the whole. Each department was, in its own terms, performing. Together they were producing a company that could not compete. Ford's transformation — working across every silo under a single, shared quality standard — produced the Ford Taurus in 1986. It became the best-selling car in America. The silo was not a structural inconvenience. It was a competitive liability. And breaking it was not a culture initiative. It was a survival decision.

The moment silo behaviour is tolerated from someone senior enough that the organisation assumes they are untouchable, the silo culture is officially endorsed.

Non-Negotiable Four: People as Source, Not Resource.

Not to be extracted from, optimised, and managed at minimum cost. To be partnered with, developed, invested in, and respected as the irreplaceable source of creativity, wisdom, energy, and commitment that no system can replace.

Deloitte's global research found that organisations investing significantly in people development see 11% greater profitability and are twice as likely to be in the top quartile of financial performance — a finding consistent across North America, Europe, India, and Asia-Pacific. This is not HR philosophy. It is the CEO's personal operating standard.

The Personal Standard: Talk It. Connect It. Reject Everything Else.

All four non-negotiables flow from one personal practice the CEO must maintain without exception.

Talk Purpose all the time. In every meeting, every review, every conversation — not as a reminder, but as the source from which everything flows.

Talk Strategy all the time. The living, breathing daily filter — Where to Play, How to Win — applied visibly to every choice the CEO makes.

Connect everything to Purpose and Strategy. Every initiative, every investment, every hire, every client, every budget line — connected or refused. No exceptions.

Reject everything that does not connect. Visibly. Persistently. With a clear explanation of why.

When the CEO does this consistently, something remarkable starts to happen. People begin to apply the filter themselves. They arrive at meetings having already tested their proposals against Purpose and Strategy. They do not need to be told what is aligned and what is not. They have learned to see it.

That is culture change. Not declared. Not programmed. Lived.

Exercises — Chapter 8: Assert the Standard

Rate yourself from 1–10 on each non-negotiable. Then write your most specific evidence for the rating:

— **NFR:** How many follow-ups did you send last week that should not have been necessary? What does that number reveal?

— **World-Class Standards:** Name one function where you know the global best practice, and name the specific gap between that and your current reality.

— **Break the Silo:** Where is silo behaviour most damaging to your organisation right now? What has it cost? And what have you actually done about it?

— **People as Source:** In your last five significant people decisions, were they made as a manager extracting output — or as a leader unlocking potential?

Exercise 2: The Personal Standard Audit

In your last significant leadership meeting:

— How many times did you explicitly connect the discussion to Purpose?

— How many times did you connect it to Strategy?

— How many times did you refuse something that did not connect to either?

— What did you model — a strategic leader or an operational one?

Exercise 3: Hard vs. Serious

— Write the most honest description of yourself as a hard leader. What do people experience when they are under pressure from you?

— Write the most honest description of yourself as a serious leader. What do people experience when you are at your best?

— What is the ratio? Which version shows up more? In what circumstances does it flip?

— What is the one change — specific, behavioural, visible — that would move the ratio toward serious?

The CEO Commitment Charter

I, _____, as CEO of _____, hereby commit to building a High-Performance Organisation.

Our Purpose: _____

Our Where to Play: _____

Our How to Win: _____

I personally commit to the following non-negotiable changes in my own behaviour:

— I will stop: _____

— I will start: _____

— I will hold the standard of: _____

— I will model: _____

I commit to all four non-negotiables — in myself first:

— No Follow-Up Required, beginning with myself

— World-class standards, in every function

— Break the silo — I will refuse departmental loyalty above organisational loyalty

— People as Source — I will treat every person as a source, not a resource

CEO Signature: _____

Date: _____

This charter is not complete until it is shared. Give a copy to one person who will hold you to it.

The ASSERT section is complete. You have chosen. You have demanded. You have set the standard — in yourself first, then in every level of the organisation.

Now it is time to Run.

R | *Run*

Build High Performance that lasts.